frequency and seniority, with India eventually establishing ‘2+2’ dialogues —involving the external affairs and defence ministers—with all three partner countries. Civilian nuclear agreements and defence logistics agreements were concluded. (India also concluded maritime logistics agreements with other Indo–Pacific countries such as France, Oman, and Singapore.) Eventually, relations between India, Japan, Australia, and the United States were elevated to the Quad among the foreign ministers and Australia was reincorporated into the Malabar naval exercises for the first time since 2007. [31]

In the Indian Ocean, India stepped up its resources and capabilities after 2017. These included policy changes in the Indian Navy to ensure year-round patrolling by surface vessels, submarines, or aircraft in seven identified zones around the Indian Ocean, from the Gulf of Aden to the Strait of Malacca. These mission-based deployments also ensured greater operational readiness, with vessels travelling armed and equipped. Greater resources were also placed in bilateral white shipping agreements, information fusion centres for maritime domain awareness, and bilateral liaison arrangements to share maritime security information with partner countries. Logistic agreements—including those involving refuelling and replenishment—also proliferated between India and Indo–Pacific partners. These helped to increase the number of turnaround points used by the Indian Navy, improving its operational reach and effectiveness.

Although Indian Ocean and relations with Quad countries improved steadily, another aspect of India’s Act East policy proved somewhat more frustrating: engagement with Southeast Asia. India had rhetorically elevated its ‘Look East’ Policy to ‘Act East’ in a bid to widen the agenda beyond economic relations, increase the scope to the broader Indo–Pacific, and add urgency to its agenda. As part of this effort, India hosted all ten leaders of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) for Republic Day celebrations. India began to increase security cooperation with several southeast Asian states over the next decade, including training arrangements with Singapore, joint naval exercises with Vietnam and Thailand, and military exports to Myanmar and the Philippines. But while trade relations